2.7 Conclusion

Our theoretical framework forms the foundation of our central hypotheses: When populists rise to power, IOs respond by adopting strategies of appeasement and sidelining—both of populist leaders and their constituents—to counteract the perceived threats these leaders pose to global governance. These strategies reflect a calculated effort by IOs to mitigate populist disruptions while safeguarding their missions and legitimacy.

Having developed our theoretical argument and clarified key concepts and definitions, we now turn to empirical tests that systematically examine these ideas. In the chapters that follow, we present innovative approaches to demonstrate how populists disproportionately undermine IOs, employing the tactics we have outlined. We then delve into the strategies IOs use to push back, shedding light on their capacity to navigate these challenges.

By building on existing scholarship on IO legitimacy and the driving forces behind populism, we also assess the broader implications of these defensive strategies. Ultimately, we argue that these approaches not only counter populist attacks but also enhance IO resilience, enabling these institutions to adapt and endure in an era of rising populist pressures. Through this exploration, we highlight how global governance evolves under strain, offering insights into its capacity to weather existential threats.

1. Even the ability to set the deliberative agenda carries significant benefits (Arias 2022; Arias, Clark, and Kaya 2024).

2. See also Freeman, Carroll, and Hannan (1983) on the "liability of newness."

3. Rob Merrick, "US Isolated Over UNRWA Funding Freeze After UK Restores Support." Devex, July 19, 2024.

4. Max Griera, "Morawiecki to Be Elected ECR Party President." *Politico.* January 13, 2024.

5. Krzysztof Pelc, "The US Broke a Global Trade Taboo. But Here's Why the US Measures May Be Legal." *Washington Post.* Monkey Cage. June 2018.

6. "World Bank Under Fire for Being 'Missing in Action' on Climate Change." *Financial Times.* December 13, 2021.

7. Amanda Shendruk and Zachary Rosenthal, "Funding the United Nations: What Impact Do US Contributions Have on UN Agencies and Programs?" *Council on Foreign Relations.* 2021. https://on.cfr.org/3D6KPMW.

8. Interview with WTO official, October 2022.